

The Game in Fifteen Minutes

Field, scoring and clock: the lines on the grass, the five ways to score, and the two clocks that decide what a team can afford to do.

Two minutes left in the first half. A receiver catches a pass over the middle, gets tackled, and everyone sprints back to the line while the clock keeps ticking. One play later a different receiver catches the *same* length of pass at the sideline and dives out of bounds, and the broadcaster says “smart, he stopped the clock.” A few drives after that, a team facing fourth down a yard from the end zone sends out its kicker, and the home crowd boos the three free points. Why does stepping on a white line save time? Why would anyone boo a sure field goal? And why did the ball start on the left side of the field on one play and the right side on the next? This chapter is the skeleton everything else in the book hangs on: the field, the scoring and the clock.

Here is a fact to keep in mind as you read. An NFL broadcast lasts about three hours, the game clock covers sixty minutes, and the ball is actually live for only about **eleven**.¹ Stitch every snap together and a whole game fits inside one fifteen-minute quarter, with time to spare. The other 49 minutes of game clock and two-plus hours of broadcast are what the rest of this book is about: the decisions, the preparation and the waiting between those few seconds of action. Most of what makes those decisions hard comes from the three things in this chapter.

You’ll be able to...

- Name every marking on an NFL field, say what it is for, and say which lines are in bounds and which are out.
- Find the field side and the boundary side on any snap, and explain why the hash the ball sits on changes what both teams do (and why college football looks so much wider).
- Score any play (touchdown, extra point, two-point try, field goal, safety) and explain why the gap between seven points and three drives so many coaching decisions.
- Say, after any play, whether the game clock is running and when it will start again.
- Tell the game clock from the play clock, and say what each one forces a team to do.
- Sketch the shape of a game: coin toss, kickoffs, possessions, quarters, the two-minute warning, halftime and overtime.

The field: a 120-yard grid

An NFL field is a rectangle 120 yards long and $53\frac{1}{3}$ yards (160 feet) wide.² It’s easiest to learn as three pieces: a 100-yard **field of play** in the middle and a 10-yard end zone at each end. Everything painted on it exists for one of three reasons: to measure progress, to mark where the ball must start, or to mark where the game stops.

¹David Biderman, “11 Minutes of Action,” *The Wall Street Journal* (Jan. 15, 2010), which timed four broadcasts from one late-December weekend and found an average of about 11 minutes of live play (10 minutes 43 seconds) in broadcasts of about three hours (174 minutes): <https://www.wsj.com/articles/SB10001424052748704281204575002852055561406> (paywalled; the same study is summarized in a Fox Sports report, “Football games have 11 minutes of action,” Jan. 18, 2010: <https://www.foxsports.com/stories/nfl/football-games-have-11-minutes-of-action>).

²NFL, *Official Playing Rules of the National Football League* (2026 edition), Rule 1, Sections 1–2 (a field 360 by 160 feet; end lines, sidelines and goal lines; the 6-foot white border; yard-line markings every 5 yards; inbounds lines “70 feet, 9 inches” from each sideline; 1-yard marks; field numerals whose bottoms begin 12 yards in from each sideline and that are 2 yards tall; the 1-yard-long marks two yards from each goal line), and Rule 3, Section 11, Article 9 (yard lines are named “A’s 19,” “B’s 49”): <https://operations.nfl.com/the-rules/nfl-rulebook/>

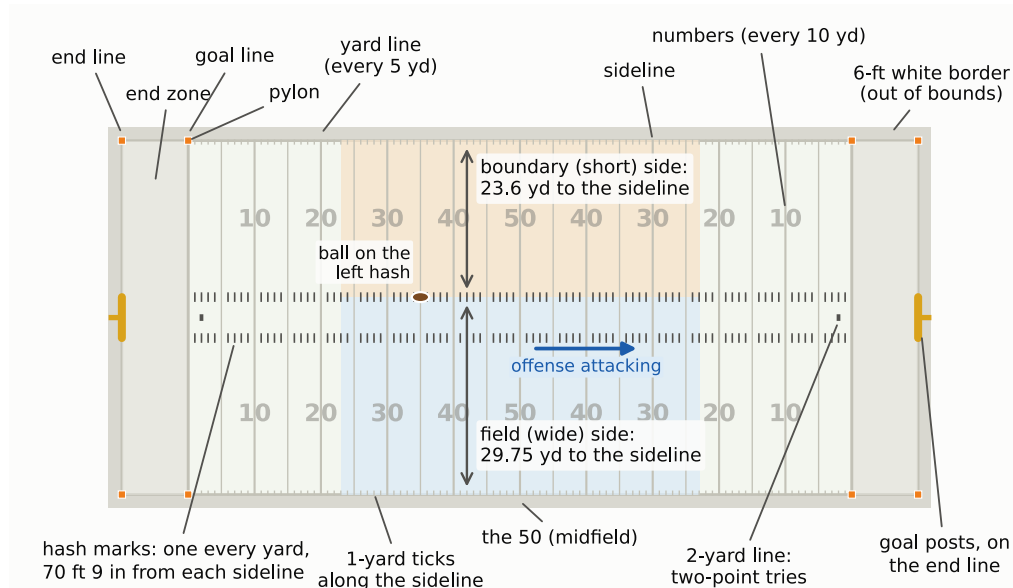


Figure 1: An NFL field from above, every marking labelled. The offense is attacking to the right, and the ball sits on the hash to the offense's left, at its own 35. The tinted bands show what that does to the field: 23.6 yards of room between the ball and the near sideline (the boundary, or short, side, top) and 29.75 yards to the far one (the field, or wide, side, bottom).

Yard lines and numbers: measuring progress

A **yard line** is any line across the field, parallel to the goal lines. Lines are painted every 5 yards, with short ticks at every single yard along both sidelines and in the two rows of hash marks, and big numbers every 10 yards. The numbers count *up* from each goal line to the 50 and back down again: there is a 10, 20, 30 and 40 on each half, and only one 50. That's why a broadcaster never says "the 70-yard line." A spot is named by its distance from the nearer goal line *and* by whose half it's in: "first down at their own 25," "first-and-goal at the Chiefs' 8." The rulebook puts it the same way: the line 19 yards from team A's goal line is "A's 19," and the line 51 yards from it is "B's 49." The tops of the numbers, about 14 yards in from each sideline, are also a landmark receivers line up on, which you'll meet as the numbers.

Why paint so much? Because almost every rule that matters is a distance: how far the offense must go to keep the ball, where a penalty is enforced, where the next play starts. The grid lets 22 players, 7 officials and a television audience agree on where the ball is, to the yard, without a tape measure. The basic bargain, in one sentence: the offense gets four tries, called *downs*, to move the ball 10 yards; make it and it earns a fresh set (a *first down*), fail on *fourth down* and the ball goes to the other team. Every play starts from the *line of scrimmage*, the yard line where the ball sits before the snap. All of that, plus the yellow line you see on TV, is the subject of Downs, Distance, and Field Position.

End zone, goal line, end line

The **end zone** is the 10-yard-deep box at each end, between the **goal line** and the **end line**. An offense scores by getting the ball into the end zone it is attacking, and it defends the one behind it. The **goal line** is the line between the field of play and the end zone, and it has one property that surprises most new fans: **the goal line is part of the end zone**. A ball carried *onto* the goal line is already a touchdown. Officials talk about the ball "breaking the plane": the goal line is treated as an invisible wall rising straight up from the paint, and the moment any part of the ball, in a runner's control, touches that wall, the play is over and six points go on the board. The orange pylons at the four corners of each end zone are in the end zone too, so a ball carried over or inside a pylon counts.³

The goal posts stand on the end line, at the *back* of the end zone. Their crossbar is 10 feet off the ground, the uprights are 18 feet 6 inches apart and rise 35 feet above the crossbar.⁴ They haven't always been there; we'll see why they moved when we get to the field goal.

³NFL rulebook (2026), Rule 11, Section 2, Article 1 (a touchdown when the ball is "on, above, or behind the plane of the opponent's goal line," including a ball that passes "over or inside the pylon"); Rule 3, Section 11, Article 3 ("The goal line and the pylons are in the end zone"); Rule 3, Section 20, Article 1 (a player is out of bounds "when he touches a boundary line"): <https://operations.nfl.com/the-rules/nfl-rulebook/>

⁴NFL rulebook (2026), Rule 1, Section 3: a crossbar 18 feet 6 inches long whose top is 10 feet above the ground, "in the plane of each end line," and uprights that "extend 35 feet above the crossbar": <https://operations.nfl.com/the-rules/nfl-rulebook/>

Sidelines: where the game stops

A **sideline** is one of the two long boundary lines. Together with the end lines, the sidelines enclose the playing surface, and a solid white border at least 6 feet wide runs outside them. Here is the rule that matters more than any other on this page: **the sideline is out of bounds**. So is the end line. A runner who puts one toe on the white paint is out of bounds, and the play ends where the ball was when he did it. The goal line is in, the boundary lines are out. Here are the edge cases.

- 1 Touchdown.**
Any part of the ball, held by a runner, breaks the plane of the goal line.
- 2 Touchdown.**
The ball is on the line. The goal line belongs to the end zone.
- 3 Not yet.**
His shoulder is over the line, but the ball is short of it. Only the ball counts.
- 4 Touchdown.**
Ball over the pylon. The pylon is in the end zone too.
- 5 Out of bounds.**
A foot on the sideline: he is out where the ball was, at the 4.
- 6 Incomplete.**
A receiver's foot on the end line. The end line is out of bounds.

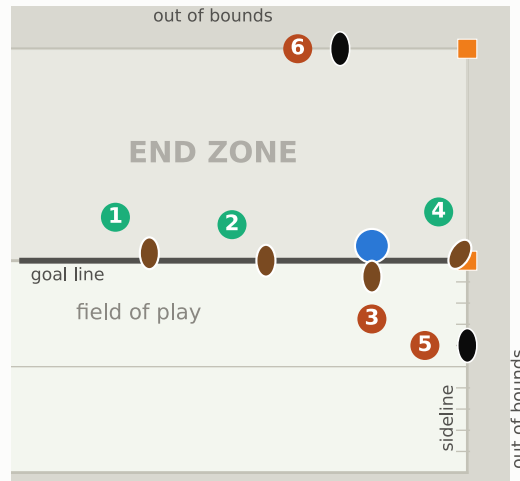


Figure 2: The goal line is in; the sideline and end line are out. A close-up of one corner of an end zone, offense attacking up the page. Only the ball counts for a touchdown (cases 1 to 4), but for out of bounds, any part of the player counts (cases 5 and 6).

The asymmetry is deliberate. The end zone is a reward, so the rules are generous about reaching it: the ball only has to *touch* the plane. The sidelines are a limit, so the rules are strict about crossing them: a toenail on the paint is enough. Notice also that the two tests look at different things. For a touchdown, only the ball matters, so a runner can be falling out of bounds and still score if the ball crossed the plane first (case 4). For out of bounds, the *player* matters: if any part of him touches the line while he holds the ball, the ball is out at that spot, even if the ball itself is still over the field.

🔥 Common misconception

“He has to get into the end zone.” A *runner* doesn’t: only the ball does, which is why you see backs stretch the ball out over the goal line while their bodies are being driven backward. A *receiver* catching a pass in the end zone is different. He has to complete the catch with both feet (or a knee, hip or elbow) down in bounds, which is why the toe-tap along the back line gets reviewed so often. What counts as a catch is its own small body of law; it’s in Officiating, Replay, and the Rules of the Ball.

Hash marks: where every play starts

Look down the middle of the field and you’ll see two rows of short dashes running its whole length. These are the **hash marks** (the rulebook calls them *inbounds lines*), and in the NFL they sit 70 feet 9 inches in from each sideline, which leaves them 18 feet 6 inches apart. That gap is exactly the width of the goal posts, and that’s no accident, as you’ll see below.

The rule that makes them matter is simple. **Every play from scrimmage starts with the ball on or between the hash marks.** If a play ends between them, the next one starts where the ball was declared dead. If it ends outside them, say a runner is tackled 4 yards from the sideline or runs out of bounds, the officials carry the ball in to the nearer hash. So most snaps start on one hash or the other, and the ball’s position across the field changes from play to play. Watch for it: the camera will show the ball sitting on the left or the right hash far more often than dead center.

Why it exists: the indoor game of 1932

The NFL didn't always have hash marks. Before 1933, the next play generally started where the last one ended, so a runner tackled a yard from the sideline left his team snapping the ball a yard from the sideline, with almost no room on one side of the formation. Teams were stuck with a lopsided formation and often spent a play just running back toward the middle to get room back. The fix came from an accident. The 1932 season ended with the Chicago Bears and the Portsmouth Spartans tied for first, and a blizzard drove the playoff game indoors to Chicago Stadium, onto a makeshift field only 80 yards long and 30 feet narrower than normal, with the stands right up against the sidelines. A special rule for that game let the ball be moved in from the walls after plays that ended near them (accounts differ on the details). The game worked so well that for 1933 the league wrote the idea into the rulebook: the ball would be spotted on the hash marks on every play.⁵

The hashes then crept toward the middle of the field. They were 10 yards from the sidelines in 1933, 15 yards from 1935, 20 yards from 1945, and in 1972 the NFL moved them to 23 yards, 1 foot and 9 inches, the same width as the goal posts.⁶ Each move gave the offense more room to the short side and made the field more symmetrical. The 1972 change was made to help offenses after a drop in scoring, one of a string of 1970s rule changes with the same aim, a story told in *From the Single Wing to the Scoring Drought*.⁷

Field side and boundary side

When the ball is on a hash, it is no longer in the middle of the field, so the two sides of the formation are different sizes. The side with more room is the **field side**, also called the **wide side**. The side closer to the sideline is the **boundary side**, or **short side**. In the NFL the difference is 23.6 yards versus 29.75 yards: about 6 yards. When the ball is in the middle of the field, neither side is the field side, and teams use some other rule (usually the formation's strong side) to decide which way to call things.

Six yards may not sound like much, but the sideline acts like a twelfth defender: a runner or receiver headed toward it runs out of room, and the defense can use it to trap him. So the hash changes the plan on both sides of the ball:

- **Offense.** Plays that need room to run sideways (sweeps, wide runs, screens to the outside, receivers breaking toward the sideline) usually go to the field. Throws to the boundary are shorter, because the quarterback is closer to that sideline, so quick throws outside are safer there. Many offenses line up their bunched receivers to the wide side so they have room to spread out, and leave one receiver alone to the boundary.
- **Defense.** Many defenses assign roles by side rather than by left and right: a "field corner" and a "boundary corner," a field safety and a boundary safety. The boundary corner can play more aggressively, because the sideline guards half of his space; the field corner has acres to defend. Playing a different coverage to each side is a whole family of schemes, which you'll meet in *Disguise*, *Rotation*, and *Split-Field Coverage*.
- **Kickers.** A field goal from a hash is kicked at a slight angle. Because NFL hashes are only as wide as the uprights, the angle is mild, which is one reason NFL teams rarely spend a down moving the ball to the middle before a kick.

NFL versus college versus high school

The hash marks are the biggest difference between the fields you see on Saturday and Sunday. College hashes are 40 feet apart, 60 feet from each sideline; high school hashes are 53 feet 4 inches apart, splitting the field into thirds.⁸ The fields are the same size. The only thing that changes is where the ball can start.

⁵Pro Football Hall of Fame, "The First Playoff Game": the December 18, 1932 Bears-Spartans game was moved into Chicago Stadium on a field "only 80 yards long and 30 feet narrower" than regulation, with "the sidelines butted up against the stands"; for 1933 the league required "the ball be spotted on the hashmarks on every play" and moved the goal posts "from the end line to the goal line": <https://profootballhof.com/football-history/the-first-playoff-game>. Accounts of the game's special sideline rule differ (some say the ball went to inbounds lines 10 yards from the walls, others that it could be brought in 15 yards at the cost of a down): "1932 NFL Playoff Game," Wikipedia: https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/1932_NFL_Playoff_Game. Before 1933, "all plays began where the ball was declared dead": "Hash mark (sports)," Wikipedia: https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Hash_marks

⁶Pro Football Hall of Fame, NFL history by year: 1933 ("inbounds line or hashmarks ... adopted" from the 1932 game), <https://www.profootballhof.com/football-history/football-history/1869-1939/1933>; 1935 ("moved nearer the center of the field, 15 yards from the sidelines"), <https://www.profootballhof.com/football-history/football-history/1869-1939/1935>; 1945 ("moved from 15 yards away from the sidelines to nearer the center of the field - 20 yards from the sidelines"), <https://www.profootballhof.com/football-history/football-history/1940-1959/1945>; 1972 ("moved nearer the center of the field, 23 yards, 1 foot, 9 inches from the sidelines"), <https://www.profootballhof.com/football-history/football-history/1960-1979/1972>. The 1933 distance (10 yards, i.e. 30 feet) is from "Hash mark (sports)," Wikipedia: https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Hash_marks

⁷The motive: the Associated Press report of the owners' vote ran as "Owners give offense big seven-yard boost" (*Rome News-Tribune*, Mar. 24, 1972, p. 6A, cited in "1972 NFL season," Wikipedia: https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/1972_NFL_season); *Sports Illustrated*, "High on the Hash" (Aug. 28, 1972), tied it to the low scoring of 1971: <https://vault.si.com/vault/1972/08/28/high-on-the-hash>

⁸NFL Football Operations, 2026 rulebook page, field markings: "The location of the inbounds hash marks is 70' 9" for professional football, 60' for college football": <https://operations.nfl.com/the-rules/nfl-rulebook/> (the NCAA rules, Rule 1-2, likewise put the inbounds lines 60 feet from the sidelines). College hashes have been 40 feet apart since 1993, the spacing the NFL used from 1945 to 1971, and high-school hashes are 53 feet 4 inches from each sideline: "Hash mark (sports)," Wikipedia, citing the *Milwaukee Journal* (Mar. 26, 1993): https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Hash_marks

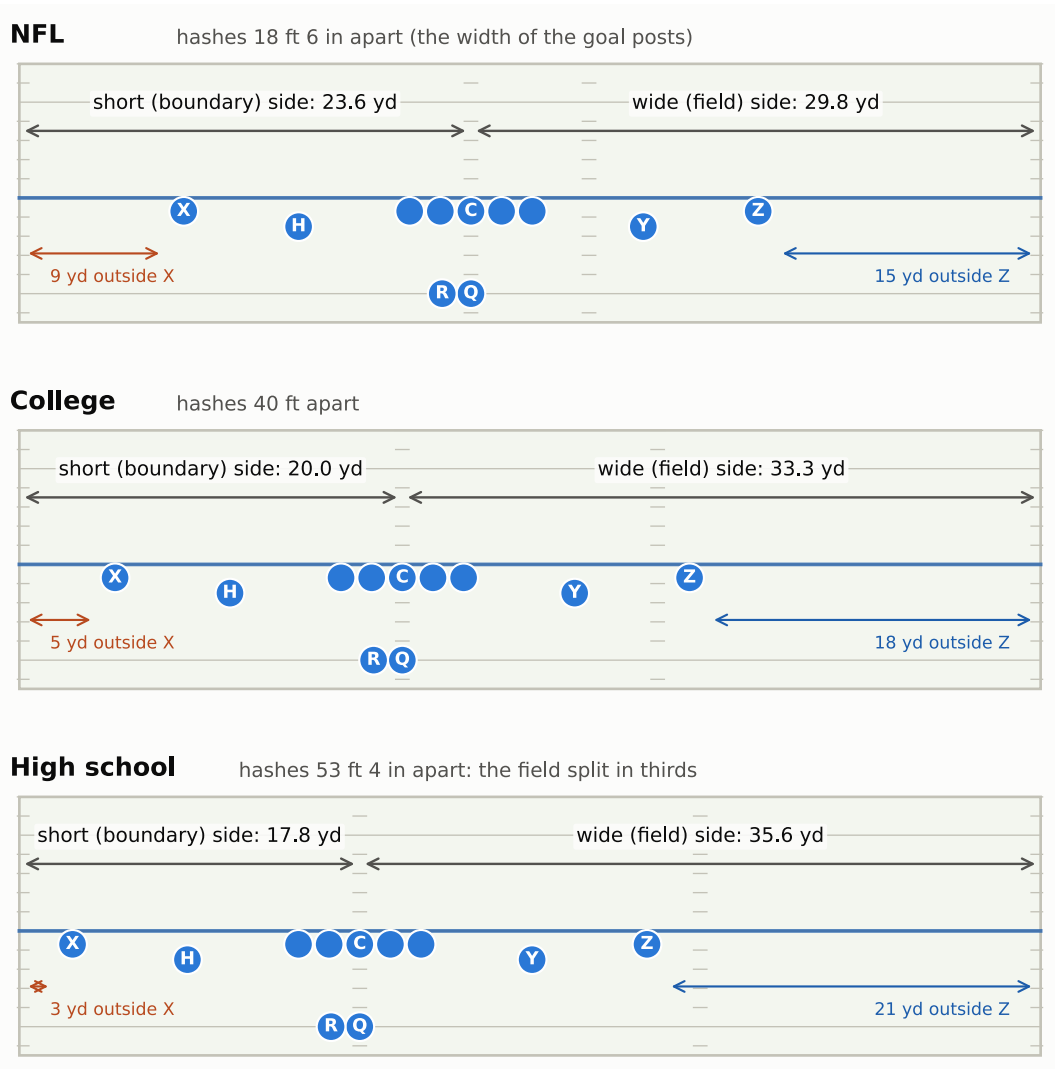


Figure 3: Same formation, same splits from the ball, three sets of hash marks. With the ball on the left hash, the NFL field is nearly symmetrical (23.6 yards to one sideline, 29.8 to the other). College gives the wide side two-thirds more room than the short side, and high school gives it twice as much. Look at the lone receiver on the left: on a high-school field he is almost standing on the sideline.

This one measurement explains a lot of the difference between college and pro offense. A college offense with the ball on the hash has a huge wide side to attack and a cramped short side, so the field itself tells everyone where the space is, and college schemes lean hard on “to the field” and “into the boundary” rules. An NFL field is close to symmetrical, so alignment and play design depend less on the hash and more on the formation and the defense. It’s also why an NFL quarterback has to make the throw outside to *both* sides of the field: there is no cramped short side where every out route is a short toss, and the boundary throw is almost as long as the field throw. The college game as the sport’s laboratory is a recurring thread in *The College Laboratory*.

Scoring: five ways onto the scoreboard

There are only five ways to score, and three of them come in a bundle: the touchdown and the two kinds of try that follow it.⁹

⁹NFL rulebook (2026), Rule 11, Section 1, Article 2 (touchdown 6, field goal 3, safety 2, try 1 or 2); Rule 11, Section 3 (the try: snapped “15 yards from the defensive team’s goal line for a Try kick” or “two yards” for a run or pass; the game clock does not run; two points for a touchdown by either team; one point for what would ordinarily be a safety): <https://operations.nfl.com/the-rules/nfl-rulebook/>

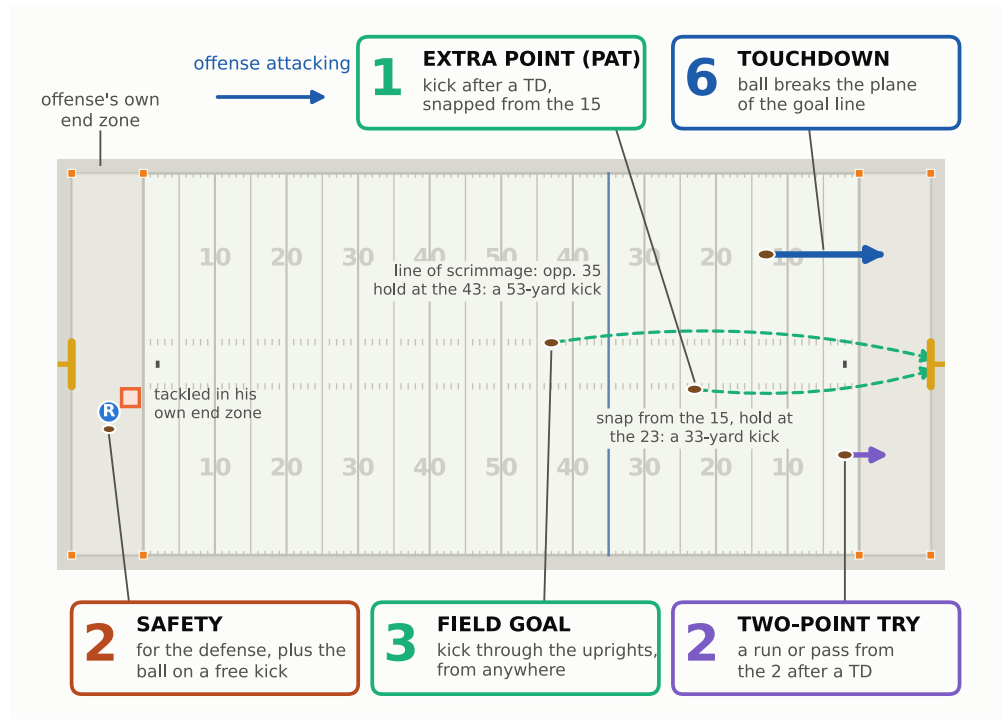


Figure 4: The five scores and where each one happens, offense attacking to the right. Four happen at the end the offense is attacking. The safety happens at the other end, in the offense's own end zone, and it counts for the defense. Field goals and extra points are measured to the goal posts, which stand on the end line, so a kick is about 18 yards longer than the line of scrimmage.

Touchdown: six points

A **touchdown** is worth six points. The offense scores one by running the ball across the goal line, or by catching a pass in the end zone. The defense or a kick-return team can score one too, by intercepting a pass or picking up a fumble and returning it all the way, or by returning a kick. Any recovery of a loose ball in the opponent's end zone also counts. The touchdown is the point of the whole enterprise, and it is not easy: in 2025, only 23% of the times an NFL team got the ball ended with one.

The try: one point or two

After every touchdown, the scoring team gets one more snap, called the *try*, and the clock doesn't run during it. It chooses between two very different plays:

- The **extra point** (also the **PAT**, for "point after touchdown") is a kick through the uprights worth one point. Since 2015 it has been snapped from the 15-yard line, so the kick itself, from about the 23, is about 33 yards.¹⁰
- The **two-point conversion** is one ordinary play from the 2-yard line: run or pass the ball into the end zone and you get two points. The NFL adopted it only in 1994; the old AFL had used it in the 1960s and college football since 1958.¹¹

On the try the defense can score too: if it blocks the kick, or intercepts or recovers on a two-point try, and returns the ball the length of the field, it gets two points. That rule also dates from 2015.

Why have two options at all? Because they are worth almost exactly the same on average, which makes the choice depend on the *score*, not on the *play*.

¹⁰NFL.com, "NFL moves extra point to 15-yard line for 2015 season" (May 2015), which also reports the new rule letting the defense return a blocked kick or failed two-point try for two points: <https://www.nfl.com/news/nfl-moves-extra-point-to-15-yard-line-for-2015-season-0ap3000000493347>

¹¹Pro Football Hall of Fame, "2-point conversion turns 30 years old" (2024): <https://www.profootballhof.com/news/2-point-conversion-turns-30-years-old> ; *Deseret News*, "NFL officially adopts 2-point conversion" (Mar. 23, 1994): <https://www.deseret.com/1994/3/23/19098606/nfl-officially-adopts-2-point-conversion/> . College football has used it since 1958 and the AFL used it from 1960 to 1969 (same PFHOF article).

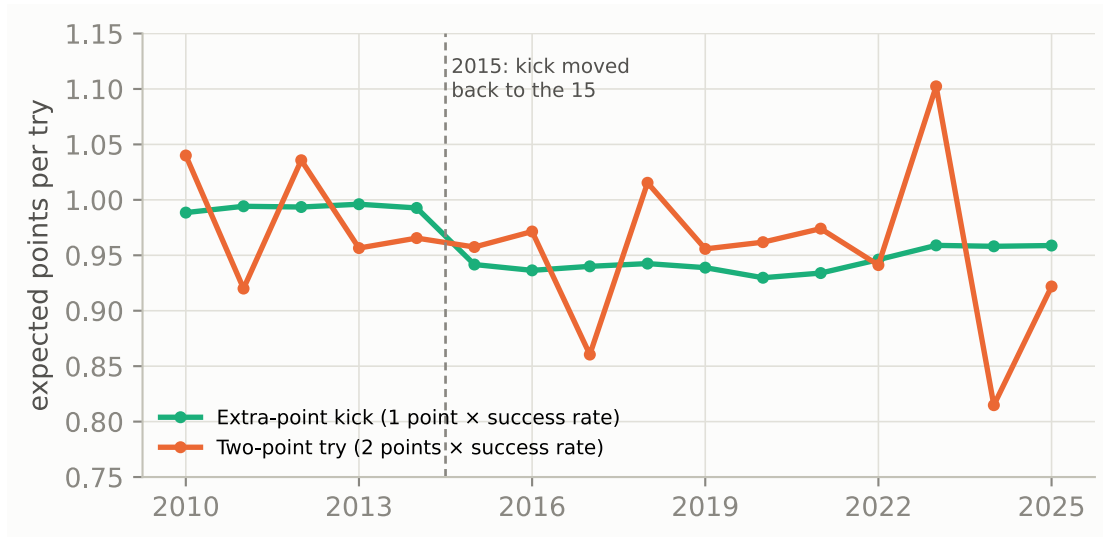


Figure 5: Expected points per try, NFL regular seasons 2010–2025: the success rate times the points. Before 2015 the extra point, kicked from the 2, was a near-certain 1 point. Moving it back to the 15 cut its success to about 93–96%. The two-point try succeeds roughly half the time, so it is worth about the same; it bounces from year to year because there are only about 90–150 attempts a season.

The chart shows the history.¹² For most of football history the extra point was close to automatic: 99.3% of kicks were good in 2014, when the ball was snapped from the 2 and the kick was a 20-yarder. A play that is always successful isn’t a decision, and the league moved the kick back to make it one. It worked a little: success fell to 94.2% the next season, and teams more than doubled their two-point attempts, from about 57 a season before the change to about 133 in 2021–2025. They’re still only about 10% of all tries, because when the two options are worth the same, most coaches take the one with less variance.

The real reason to go for two is the scoreboard. A team that trails by 2 after scoring wants the tie, and only the two-pointer gives it. A team that trails by 8 needs a touchdown *and* a two-pointer to tie. A team that is down 14 late and scores faces a classic question: kick to get within 7, or go for two now, so that it knows whether the next touchdown will tie or win? Analysts have argued that one for a decade, and we’ll do the arithmetic in Clock and Game Management.

Field goal: three points from anywhere

A **field goal** is worth three points. The offense snaps the ball back about 7 or 8 yards to a holder, who sets it on the ground, and the kicker kicks it through the goal posts. It can be tried from anywhere on the field, on any down, but in practice teams try it on fourth down, when the alternative is giving the ball away. Because the posts stand on the end line, add about 18 yards to the line of scrimmage to get the length of the kick: a field goal tried from the opponent’s 30 is a 48-yarder.

¹²Course calculation from nflverse play-by-play, regular seasons 2010–2025: rows with an `extra_point_result` (kicks) or a `two_point_conv_result` (two-point tries), success = “good” or “success”. Tries nullified by penalties are not counted.

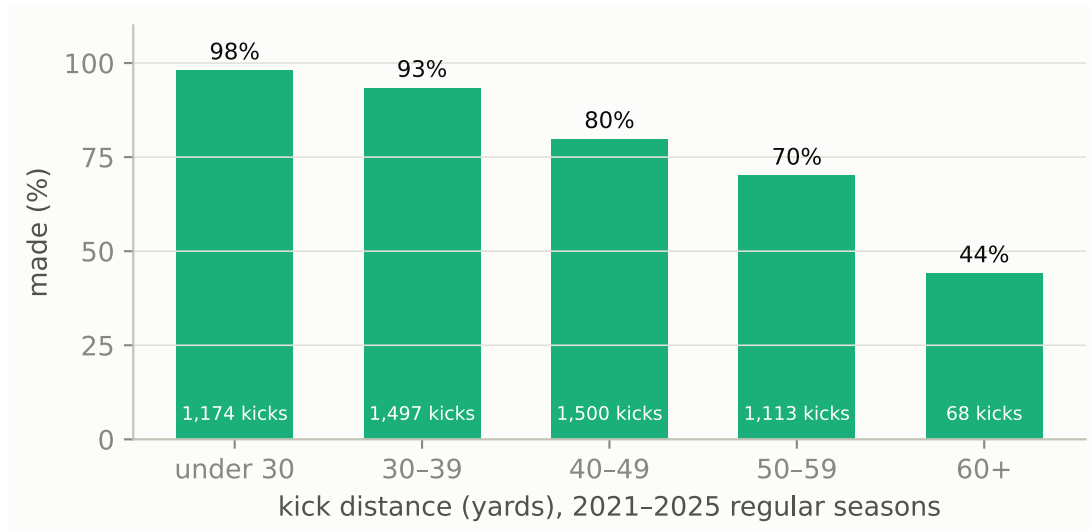


Figure 6: How often NFL field goals are made, by distance, 2021–2025 regular seasons. Inside 30 yards the kick is close to certain, and from 30–39 yards it is good more than nine times in ten; past 50 it is still made about seven times in ten. That reliability is new: in 2016 and again in 2019, kicks of 50 yards or more were made fewer than six times in ten.

Modern kickers are remarkable. Kicks from under 30 yards almost never miss, those from 30–39 miss only about one time in fifteen, and kicks of 50 yards or more, made fewer than six times in ten as recently as 2019, are now made about seven times in ten: in 2025 alone kickers made 12 field goals of 60 yards or more.¹³ That shifts strategy, because the farther out a team can count on three points, the sooner a stalled drive still scores.

The goal posts' location is a strategy story too. From 1933 to 1973 the NFL's posts stood *on the goal line*, at the front of the end zone, a holdover from that same indoor game of 1932. Field goals were 10 yards shorter, and coaches settled for them constantly. For 1974 the league moved the posts back to the end line, specifically to make field goals harder and push teams to play for touchdowns.¹⁴ The rules have been nudging coaches away from the three-point consolation prize for fifty years.

Safety: two points and the ball

A **safety** is the defense's own score: two points, awarded when the offense's ball carrier is tackled in his own end zone, when the offense fumbles the ball out of the back or side of its own end zone, or when the offense commits a foul in its own end zone (most often holding a pass rusher who was about to sack the quarterback there). The usual picture is a quarterback sacked a yard deep in his own end zone.

The safety comes with a second penalty. The team that gave it up must then *kick the ball away* from its own 20-yard line, a free kick that is usually punted. So the defense gets two points **and** the ball, often around midfield. That makes a safety worth more than its two points suggest, and it's why offenses backed up against their own goal line play so carefully. Safeties are rare: there were 12 in the whole 2025 regular season, about one every 23 games.¹⁵ (One oddity for trivia night: the rulebook even allows a *one-point* safety, which can happen only on a try. You will probably never see one.)

The word "safety" also names a defensive position, the deepest defenders on the field. That one is covered in The Twenty-Two.

Seven versus three: the central tension

Add it up and an NFL score is almost always built from 7s (touchdown plus extra point) and 3s. The gap between them, **four points**, is the single most important number in football strategy. It is more than a field goal. A team that settles for a field goal when it could have scored a touchdown has left more points on the table than it just scored.

¹³Course calculation from nflverse play-by-play, regular seasons: all field-goal attempts by `kick_distance`, 2021–2025 for the chart; 2025 alone for the count of made kicks of 60+ yards. Kicks of 50+ yards were made 57% of the time in 2016 and 58% in 2019, against 69–70% in every season from 2022 to 2025.

¹⁴Pro Football Hall of Fame, NFL history by year, 1974 ("the goal posts were moved from the goal line to the end lines," part of a package of changes adopted "to add action and tempo to games"): <https://www.profootballhof.com/football-history/football-history/1960-1979/1974>. On the purpose, Nexstar Media, "NFL goalposts used to look very different: What changed, and why they moved" (2025), citing the Hall of Fame: the move was made "in an effort to force offenses to play for touchdowns instead of field goals," and attempts fell from more than 860 the season before to 553: <https://www.abc27.com/news/nfl-goalposts-used-to-look-very-different-what-changed-and-why-they-moved/>

¹⁵NFL rulebook (2026), Rule 11, Section 5 (what is a safety; after a safety, "the team scored upon must put the ball in play by a free kick (punt, drop kick, or place kick) from its 20-yard line"): <https://operations.nfl.com/the-rules/nfl-rulebook/>. The count is a course calculation from nflverse play-by-play (`safety == 1`), 2025 regular season, 272 games.

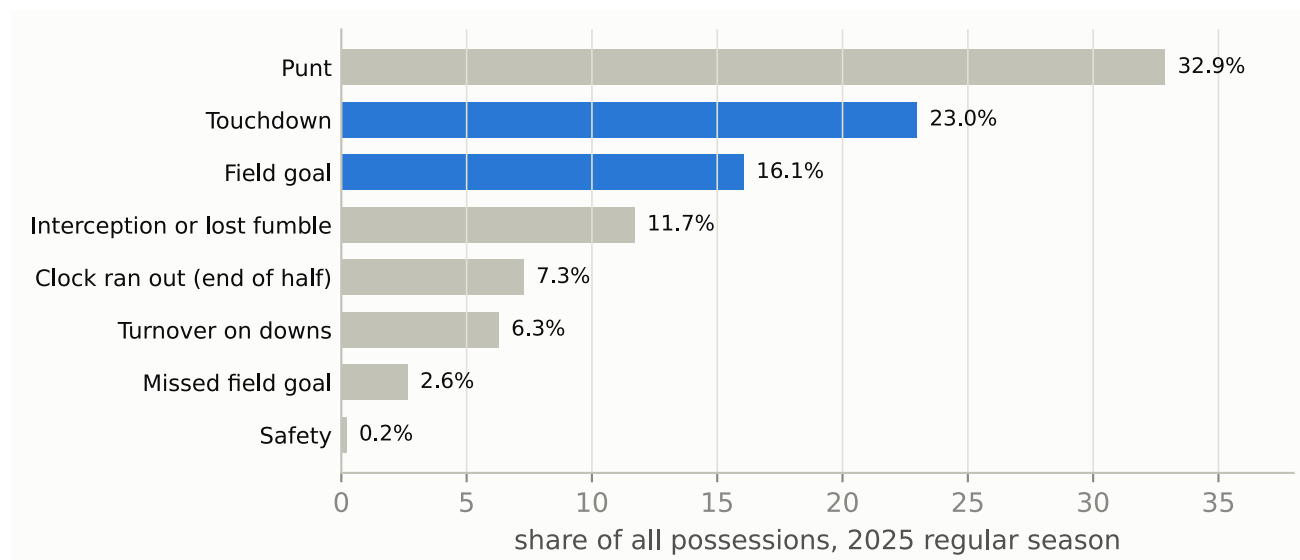


Figure 7: How every possession ended, 2025 NFL regular season. Fewer than four in ten produced points, and touchdowns outnumbered field goals only about three to two. Defensive and return touchdowns after a turnover are counted with the turnover.

Here’s why that gap matters so much. An NFL team gets only about 11 possessions (turns with the ball, the subject of the next section) a game (10.7 in 2025) and scores about 23 points.¹⁶ Each one is precious. When a drive reaches the opponent’s 20, the area called the red zone, it ended in a touchdown 57% of the time in 2025 and a field goal 29% of the time. A team that turns one of those field goals per game into a touchdown gains four points a week; over a 17-game season that’s almost 70 points, the kind of margin that separates an average team from a playoff team.

So the choice between 7 and 3 runs through every chapter that follows:

- It’s why **fourth down near the goal line** is the most second-guessed call in football, and why the crowd at the top of this chapter booed the kicker. You’ll do the math yourself in the third Predict-the-play drill below.
- It’s why offenses build whole playbooks for the red zone, where the field shrinks and the defense has less ground to cover (Red Zone, Goal Line, and Short Yardage).
- It’s why a field goal on the opening drive is greeted with a shrug and a touchdown with a roar, even though both “scored.”

! Why it exists: a scoreboard built from 7s and 3s

Because almost all points come in chunks of 7 and 3, some margins matter far more than others. Leading by 3 means a field goal ties you; by 4, the opponent needs a touchdown; by 8, it needs a touchdown *and* a two-point conversion; by 9, two scores. Broadcasters call a 9-point lead “a two-score game” for exactly this reason. Listen for the margins 3, 7, 8, 14 and 17 late in a game; they’re the ones coaches plan around, and they’re why a team up by 7 sometimes kicks a late field goal (to go up 10, two scores) instead of trying for a touchdown.

Possession: football is a game of turns

Underneath all the scoring is a simpler idea. At any moment one team has **possession**, control of the ball, and that team is the offense. The other is the defense. Unlike basketball or soccer, the teams don’t swap the ball back and forth in a flowing way; they take *turns*, and each turn (a possession, or drive) keeps going until something specific ends it:

- **The offense scores.** After a touchdown and try, or after a field goal, the scoring team *kicks off* to the other team. This is football’s built-in fairness: score, and you have to give the ball back.
- **The offense gives it up on purpose**, by punting on fourth down because it doesn’t want to risk failing to keep the ball deep in its own territory.
- **The offense loses it:** an interception, a lost fumble, or failing on fourth down (all defined in Downs, Distance, and Field Position).
- **The defense scores a safety** and then receives the free kick.

¹⁶Course calculation from nflverse play-by-play, 2025 regular season (272 games): one row per drive (`fixed_drive`), classified by `fixed_drive_result`; a red-zone trip is a drive with `drive_inside20 == 1`; points per team are final scores averaged over both teams.

- **The half ends.** Possession does *not* carry across halftime.

The chart above is really a census of how turns end. A third of possessions end in a punt; fewer than a quarter end with a touchdown. Notice how few turns there are: about eleven per team, so each one is a scarce resource. That scarcity is what makes the clock matter. A team that can't stop the clock can't buy itself another turn.

The shape of a game

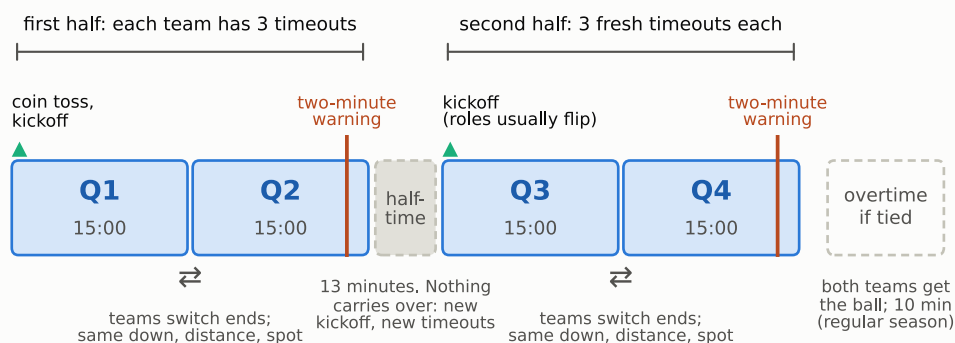


Figure 8: The shape of an NFL game in game-clock time: four 15-minute quarters, a halftime that resets the kickoff and the timeouts, a two-minute warning near the end of each half, and overtime if the score is tied. Teams switch ends after the first and third quarters but keep the ball, the down and the distance.

The coin toss. A few minutes before kickoff the referee tosses a coin at midfield, and the visiting captain calls it. The winner chooses to kick off or receive, or which goal to defend, and the loser gets the other choice. The winner can also *defer* his choice to the second half, and most coaches now do:¹⁷ they kick off to start the game and are guaranteed the ball to start the second half, which can turn into back-to-back possessions if they score just before halftime.¹⁸

The kickoff. Each half, and every possession after a score, starts with a kickoff: the kicking team kicks from its own 35-yard line and the other team catches the ball and tries to run it back. The kickoff has been rebuilt three times in three seasons (a new “dynamic” alignment in 2024, made permanent with a touchback to the 35 in 2025, and tweaked again for 2026, when an onside kick may be declared at any time) and has its own chapter, Kickoffs and Returns.¹⁹ For now: a kickoff that lands in the end zone and isn’t run out is a touchback, and the receiving team starts at its own 35.

Quarters. The game is 60 minutes of game-clock time, split into four **quarters** of 15 minutes. After the first and third quarters the teams switch ends, so neither side gets the wind or the sun for a whole half. Nothing else changes: the same team has the ball, at the mirror-image spot, with the same down and distance. A drive can run straight through the end of the first or third quarter.

Halftime. Between the second and third quarters there’s a 13-minute break (much longer at the Super Bowl, for the show). Halftime is a hard reset. Possession doesn’t carry over, unused timeouts disappear, and the second half starts with a fresh kickoff, usually by the team that received the first one.

The two-minute warning. When the game clock passes 2:00 in the second and fourth quarters, the officials stop the game: the **two-minute warning**. It’s an automatic timeout that belongs to neither team. It began as a real warning: until the NFL merged with the AFL in 1970, the official time was kept on an official’s watch on the field and the scoreboard clock was only an estimate,

¹⁷The option to defer was added in 2008. Coin-toss winners deferred 8% of the time in 2008 and 76% in the first half of the 2015 season (Ben Goessling, ESPN, Nov. 5, 2015, “For NFL teams, deferring after winning coin toss is more than a 50-50 choice”: https://www.espn.com/blog/nfcnorth/post/_id/72630/for-nfl-teams-deferring-after-winning-coin-toss-is-more-than-a-50-50-choice) and about five times in six by 2018 (Zach Barnett, FootballScoop, “The number of NFL coaches deferring the kickoff has skyrocketed in the past decade,” Sept. 7, 2018: <https://footballscoop.com/news/number-nfl-coaches-deferring-kickoff-skyrocketed-past-decade>).

¹⁸NFL rulebook (2026), Rule 4, Section 1 (four 15-minute periods; at least two minutes between the first and second and the third and fourth periods; a 13-minute halftime) and Section 2 (the visiting captain calls the coin toss; the winner may defer; teams change goals after the first and third periods with possession, down, ball position and line to gain unchanged): <https://operations.nfl.com/the-rules/nfl-rulebook/>

¹⁹NFL.com, “NFL owners vote to make dynamic kickoff permanent, adjust ball spot on touchbacks to 35-yard line” (2025): <https://www.nfl.com/news/nfl-owners-vote-to-make-dynamic-kickoff-permanent-adjust-ball-spot-on-touchbacks-to-35-yard-line>; Seattle Seahawks, “NFL announces approved rule changes for 2026 season” (onside kick declarable at any time): <https://www.seahawks.com/news/nfl-announces-approved-rule-changes-for-2026-season>. The kicker’s restraining line is the kicking team’s 35 (2026 rulebook, Rule 6, Section 1, Article 2).

so the referee told both benches exactly how much time was left.²⁰ The stadium clock has been official for more than fifty years, and the warning survives because it's useful: for strategy (it's a free stoppage for a team trying to save time) and for television (it's a guaranteed commercial break at the most tense moment of each half).

Overtime. If the score is tied after four quarters, the game goes to overtime. The rules are different for the regular season and the playoffs, and both changed recently. Since 2025, both teams get at least one possession in regular-season overtime too (the playoffs adopted this in 2022); after that, the next score wins. Regular-season overtime is one 10-minute period, and a game still tied after it ends a tie. Playoff overtime uses 15-minute periods and continues until someone wins.²¹ Overtime strategy, and what changed when the “first touchdown wins” rule went away, is in Clock and Game Management.

Put together, a game is a long chain of turns: about 150 snaps in all, roughly 121 of them runs and passes and the rest kicks.²² Sixty minutes of clock, about eleven of action, and the clock rules decide how the sixty are spent.

The game clock: when it runs and when it stops

The **game clock** is the big clock on the scoreboard and in the corner of your TV, counting down each 15-minute quarter. It is the official time. It runs during every play, which is no surprise. What surprises people is that it often keeps running *between* plays too. Whether it does depends entirely on how the last play ended.²³

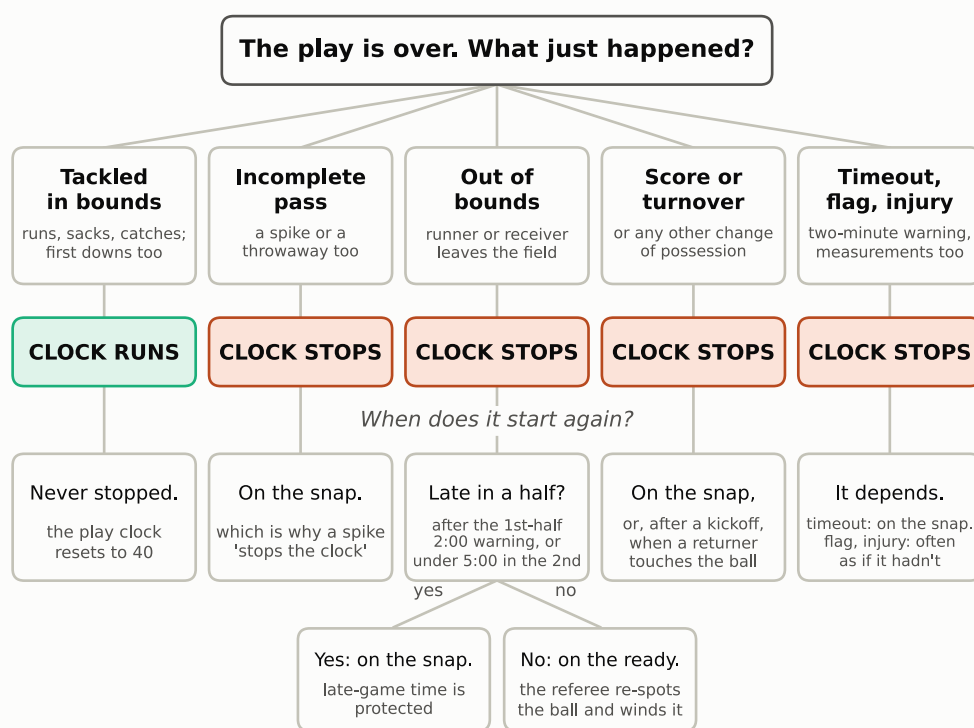


Figure 9: After this play, is the clock running? Read from the top. The one ending that keeps the clock running is a ball carrier tackled in bounds (including a sack, and including a first down). Every other ending stops it, and the question becomes when it starts again. For a play that goes out of bounds, the answer depends on the time of the game.

²⁰NFL rulebook (2026), Rule 3, Section 41: “an automatic timeout that occurs at the conclusion of the last down for which the ball is legally snapped or kicked prior to two minutes remaining on the game clock in the second and fourth periods.” On its origin: Football Zebras, “NFL100: For half of NFL history, the official time was not on the scoreboard” (Oct. 2019), which notes that official time moved to the scoreboard when the NFL adopted the AFL’s rule at the 1970 merger and that “the two-minute warning was just that — an official notification to both sidelines”: <https://www.footballzebras.com/2019/10/nfl100-for-half-of-nfl-history-the-official-time-was-not-on-the-scoreboard>

²¹NFL Football Operations, “Featured rules” (overtime: playoffs since 2022 and regular season since 2025, both teams possess; regular-season period of 10 minutes, ties possible): <https://operations.nfl.com/rules-officiating/featured-rules> ; ESPN, NFL rule changes for 2025: https://www.espn.com/nfl/story/_/id/46088927/nfl-rules-changes-tush-push-chain-gang-kickoffs-celebrations . Timeouts in overtime: 2026 rulebook, Rule 4, Section 5, Article 1.

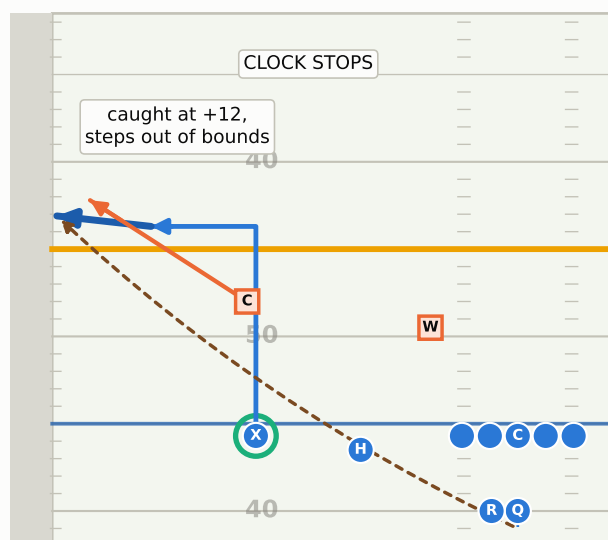
²²Course calculation from nflverse play-by-play, 2025 regular season: runs, passes, punts, field goals, extra points, kickoffs, kneels and spikes per game, both teams together (about 149), of which runs and passes about 121.

²³NFL rulebook (2026), Rule 4, Section 3 (starting the game clock: after a free kick “when the ball is legally touched in the field of play”; after a runner goes out of bounds, “on the Referee’s signal that a ball has been returned to play,” except on the snap after a change of possession, after the two-minute warning of the first half, or inside the last five minutes of the second half; after fouls, generally “as if the foul had not occurred,” with late-game exceptions) and Section 4 (stopping the game clock): <https://operations.nfl.com/the-rules/nfl-rulebook/>

Walk through it once and the logic becomes obvious:

- **A ball carrier tackled in bounds: the clock keeps running.** That includes a quarterback sacked behind the line and, in the NFL, a play that gains a first down. The officials need a few seconds to spot the ball, and those seconds tick away.
- **An incomplete pass stops the clock**, and it stays stopped until the next snap. This is why a quarterback in a hurry will *spike* the ball, throwing it straight into the turf the moment it's snapped: it's an intentional incomplete pass that buys a stopped clock for the price of a down (more in Clock and Game Management).
- **Out of bounds stops the clock**, but for most of the game only briefly. Normally, once the officials have put the ball back on the hash and the referee signals it's ready for play, the clock starts again, well before the snap. But after the two-minute warning of the first half, and in the last five minutes of the game, it stays stopped until the snap. That exception, the out-of-bounds clock rule, is why the broadcaster praised the receiver who got out of bounds in the opening scene, and why a defense protecting a late lead tries so hard to tackle receivers *inside* the field.
- **Any score or change of possession stops the clock.** After a score it starts again on the kickoff, but only when someone legally touches the ball in the field of play, so a kickoff that ends in a touchback takes no time at all. After a turnover or punt it starts on the next snap.
- **A timeout, a penalty flag, an injury, the two-minute warning or a measurement for a first down** all stop it. When it restarts varies: after a team timeout or the two-minute warning, on the snap; after most flags and injuries, the clock starts again as if the stoppage hadn't happened (so if it was running, it runs again when the ball is ready). Late in each half the rules tighten, so that a team can't use a deliberate foul or a fake injury to save time; a team that does can be charged a 10-second runoff, ten seconds taken straight off the clock.

Out route to the sideline



Dig route over the middle

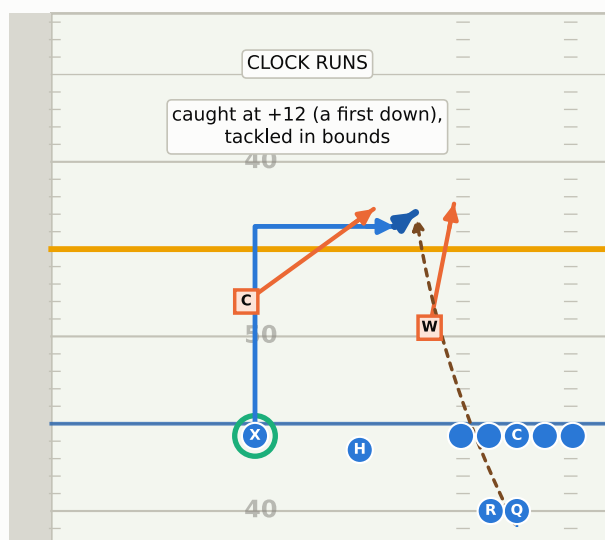


Figure 10: Same gain, two different clocks. Both receivers (X, outlined) catch the ball 12 yards downfield for a first down. On the left, the out route takes him to the sideline and he steps out: the clock stops. On the right, the dig takes him over the middle, where the corner (C) and the Will linebacker (W) tackle him in bounds: the clock keeps running while everyone hurries back to the line.

Once you see the clock this way, a lot of late-game football explains itself. A team that is **behind** wants the clock stopped, so it throws passes (an incompletion stops the clock too) and aims for the sidelines. A team that is **ahead** wants the clock running, so it runs the ball, keeps its receivers in bounds, and takes as long as the rules allow between snaps. The trailing team's defense will even let a runner gain a few extra yards rather than give up a tackle in bounds that keeps the clock moving. Late in a close game, almost every call is a clock call as much as a yardage call. Coaches have names for the two modes, the *two-minute drill* and the *four-minute offense*, and both are built out in Clock and Game Management.

🔥 Common misconception

"The clock stops on a first down." Not in the NFL, and that's a habit carried over from college football, where for decades the clock stopped briefly after every first down. Even college dropped that in 2023, except in the last two minutes of each half, to shorten games.²⁴ In the NFL a first down doesn't stop the clock. The chains move and the clock keeps running.

Timeouts

A **timeout** is a stoppage a team asks for. The head coach or any player on the field can call one. Each team gets **three per half**, and unused first-half timeouts don't carry into the second half; in regular-season overtime each team gets two.²⁵ A timeout stops the game clock at once, and the clock then starts again on the next snap.

Teams use timeouts for three different jobs, and good coaches know which job they're paying for:

1. **To stop the clock** late in a half, when time is worth more than anything. This is the most valuable use, and the reason announcers count a team's remaining timeouts aloud in the final minutes. Each one is worth roughly 40 seconds that would otherwise have run off between plays.
2. **To avoid a penalty or a bad play**, when the play clock is about to hit zero, the wrong players are on the field, or the quarterback doesn't like what the defense is showing.
3. **To talk**, or to make the other team think: a defense can call one just before a field-goal attempt to make the kicker wait (only once per kick; a second try is a penalty).

The tension is that jobs 2 and 3 spend the resource job 1 needs. A team that burns two timeouts on substitution mix-ups in the third quarter may have nothing left when it needs to stop the clock at the end of the game.

The play clock: forty seconds between snaps

The game clock isn't the only clock. A second one, the **play clock**, counts down the time between plays; you'll see it in the corner of the screen and on posts above each end zone. When a play ends, it starts at **40 seconds**, and the offense must snap the ball before it reaches zero. If it doesn't, it's a five-yard delay of game penalty. After certain administrative stoppages (a timeout, a change of possession, a penalty enforcement, the two-minute warning, the start of a quarter) the play clock starts at **25 seconds** instead, once the referee has spotted the ball and blown his whistle.²⁶

! Why it exists: two clocks, two jobs

The two clocks measure different things. The **game clock** measures how much *football* is left. The **play clock** keeps the game moving by limiting how long an offense can stand around between snaps. The 25-second version exists because after a long stoppage both teams already know what's coming and have had time to talk, so there's no need to give them 40 more seconds; the 40-second version starts the instant a play ends, so it already covers the time it takes to get up, unpile and walk back.

Most of the time the two clocks run together, and that combination is the most important arithmetic in late-game football. If the game clock is running, every snap can burn up to 40 seconds of it, plus however long the play itself takes. A team with the lead and a fresh set of downs can simply have its quarterback kneel down three times, letting the play clock run nearly to zero before each snap, and drain about two minutes without risking a fumble; that's the *victory formation* you see to end so many games, covered in Clock and Game Management. The trailing team's only defense is to stop the game clock, and its timeouts are the only tool it has. So "they have three timeouts left" really means "they can stop the bleeding three times."

The play clock also shapes everything that happens *before* a play. Choosing the play, sending it in, huddling, lining up and reading the defense all have to fit inside those 40 seconds, and the coach's radio to the quarterback even cuts out with 15 seconds left. That chain is the subject of What a Play Really Is, and what the offense does in the final seconds before the snap is The Pre-Snap Phase.

²⁴ESPN, "NCAA approves rule change to run clock after first downs" (Apr. 21, 2023; the change applies in every division except Division III, and the clock still stops after first downs in the last two minutes of each half): https://www.espn.com/college-football/story/_/id/36255797/ncaa-approves-rule-change-run-clock-first-downs

²⁵NFL rulebook (2026), Rule 4, Section 5, Article 1: "three charged team timeouts during each half and two timeouts during an overtime period in the regular season"; a second timeout by the defense to "freeze" a kicker is unsportsmanlike conduct (Item 4): <https://operations.nfl.com/the-rules/nfl-rulebook/>

²⁶NFL rulebook (2026), Rule 4, Section 6, Articles 1–2: "within 40 seconds after the start of the play clock," which starts "when a play ends"; 25 seconds "beginning with the Referee's whistle" after administrative stoppages including a change of possession, a charged team timeout, the two-minute warning, the expiration of a period and a penalty enforcement: <https://operations.nfl.com/the-rules/nfl-rulebook/>

The most famous lesson in clock rules came in the AFC Divisional round on January 23, 2022 (the 2021 season), Buffalo at Kansas City. The last two minutes produced three touchdowns. Buffalo went ahead 29–26 with 1:54 left; Kansas City answered with a 64-yard touchdown by Tyreek Hill to lead 33–29; and Josh Allen’s 19-yard touchdown pass to Gabriel Davis and the extra point put the Bills back ahead, 36–33, with **13 seconds** left.²⁷

Then three clock details decided the game:

1. **The kickoff took no time.** Buffalo’s kicker boomed the ball into the end zone for a touchback. Because the clock only starts when the ball is touched in the field of play, the Chiefs started at their own 25 with all 13 seconds still on the clock.
2. **Two completions in bounds, two timeouts.** Patrick Mahomes hit Tyreek Hill for 19 yards (the clock ran from 0:13 to 0:08, and Kansas City called timeout), then Travis Kelce for 25 yards to the Bills’ 31 (0:08 to 0:03, timeout). Neither receiver went out of bounds, which didn’t matter: Kansas City had timeouts to spend, and spent them.
3. **A 49-yard field goal at 0:03** by Harrison Butker, from the 31 (31 + 18), tied it 36–36.

Kansas City won the overtime coin toss, drove the length of the field, and won 42–36 on Mahomes’s 8-yard touchdown pass to Kelce. Under the rules then in force, that first-possession touchdown ended the game; Allen never touched the ball in overtime. The league changed playoff overtime for the next season so that both teams get a possession, and in 2025 extended that to the regular season.

What to notice: thirteen seconds was enough because of *where* the plays happened and *what the Chiefs had left*. Two timeouts plus a kickoff that didn’t run the clock turned 13 seconds into three snaps. Buffalo’s options were a short kick to make Kansas City return it (burning time) or coverage that kept everything in front, and both are now standard talking points in exactly that situation.

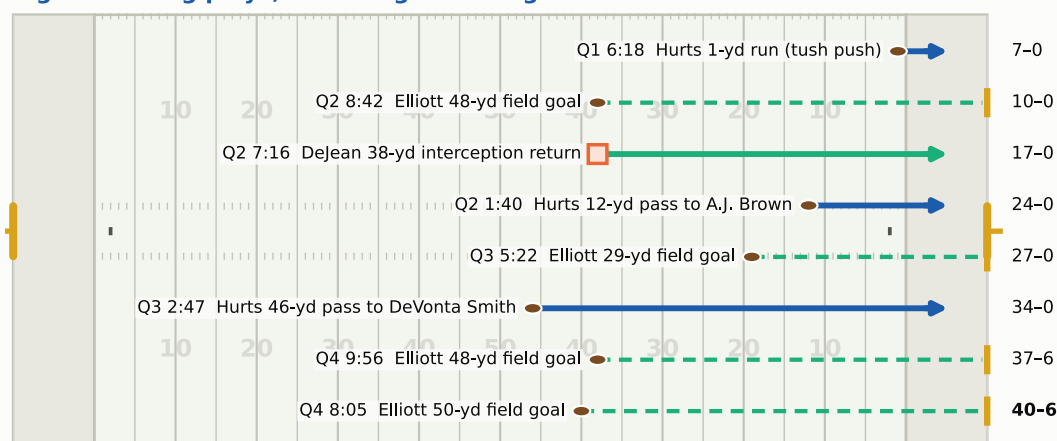
Film room: Super Bowl LIX on one field

Every type of score except the safety showed up in a single game: Super Bowl LIX, February 9, 2025, at the Caesars Superdome in New Orleans, the Eagles’ 40–22 win over the Chiefs that ended the 2024 season.²⁸ Here is every scoring play, located on the field.

²⁷Play sequence, times and scores from nflverse play-by-play, game [2021_20_BUF_KC](#) (Jan. 23, 2022), including the touchbacks, the timeouts at 0:08 and 0:03, Harrison Butker’s 49-yard field goal and the overtime touchdown; the overtime rule changes as in the NFL Football Operations “Featured rules” page and this course’s fact sheet (checked 2026-10-06).

²⁸Date, venue, score and MVP (Jalen Hurts) as in this course’s fact sheet (checked 2026-10-06), e.g. CBS News, “Jalen Hurts named Super Bowl MVP”: <https://www.cbsnews.com/amp/news/nfl-mvp-super-bowl-jalen-hurts-eagles>. Every scoring play, its time, spot and kick distance from nflverse play-by-play, game [2024_22_KC_PHI](#).

Eagles' scoring plays, attacking left to right



Chiefs' scoring plays, attacking left to right

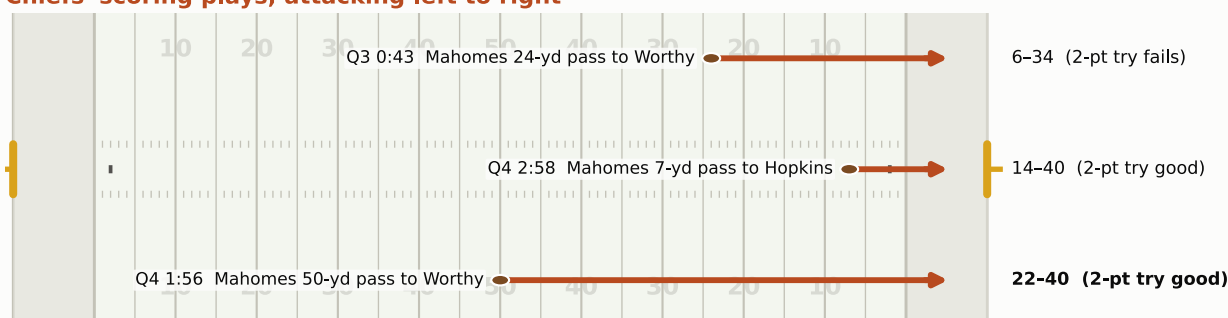


Figure 11: Super Bowl LIX, every scoring play, each drawn with the scoring team attacking left to right (in the real game the teams switched ends every quarter). Solid lines are touchdowns, starting at the line of scrimmage; the green line is Cooper DeJean's interception return, starting where he caught the ball; dashed lines are field goals, starting at the spot of the hold. The running score is at the right. Data: nflverse play-by-play.

i Film room: Eagles 2024 — Super Bowl LIX, every score

Read the Eagles' panel from the top and you get a tour of this chapter.

- **The goal line is in.** The first touchdown came from a yard out, Jalen Hurts pushed forward by his own teammates in the Eagles' famous short-yardage play, the tush push. One yard is all it took because the ball only had to touch the plane.
- **Defenses score too.** Cooper DeJean intercepted Patrick Mahomes at the Kansas City 38 and ran it back for a touchdown: six points for the Eagles while their offense sat on the bench.
- **Seven and three.** Philadelphia's scoring was four touchdowns, all followed by Jake Elliott extra points (28 points), and four Elliott field goals (12 points): 48, 29, 48 and 50 yards. Check the arithmetic on the field: the 50-yarder came from the Chiefs' 32, the 29-yarder from their 11, the 48-yarders from their 30. Line of scrimmage plus 18, every time. The 29-yarder is the one drive where the Chiefs' defense won the 7-versus-3 battle in the red zone: the Eagles reached the 11 and settled for three.
- **Going for two when far behind.** Kansas City scored three touchdowns, all after the game was decided, and went for two after every one (one failed, two succeeded): $6 + 8 + 8 = 22$. When you trail by four scores, one extra point barely matters, and two might cut the number of scores you need.
- **The clock.** It was 24-0 at halftime, which is a hard reset: Kansas City got the second-half kickoff and new timeouts, but no amount of clock management fixes a 24-point hole when an average possession is worth about two points.

What to notice when you watch it again: where each drive *stalled*. The Eagles' field goals mark the drives the Chiefs' defense held to three; the gap between those four kicks and four more touchdowns would have been 16 points.

💡 Watch for it on Sunday: the clock watcher

Pick one quarter (the second or fourth is best, because of the two-minute warning). Before **every snap**, say out loud whether the game clock is running, and why.

- **Running?** Look at the score bug before the snap. If it's ticking, the last play ended with a tackle in bounds. Say "tackled in bounds."
- **Stopped?** Name the reason: incompleteness, out of bounds, timeout, flag, score, change of possession, two-minute warning.
- **Out of bounds early in the half?** Watch the clock start again on the referee's signal, *before* the snap. Then watch it stay stopped until the snap after the two-minute warning.
- **Count the timeouts** shown in the score bug for each team, and notice when announcers start talking about them.
- **Bonus: the hash.** On each snap, note whether the ball is on the left hash, the right hash or the middle, and whether the play went to the wide side or the short side.

By the end of one quarter you won't need the chart above. You'll *feel* when the clock should be running.

Predict the play

💡 Predict the play 1: which side is the wide side?

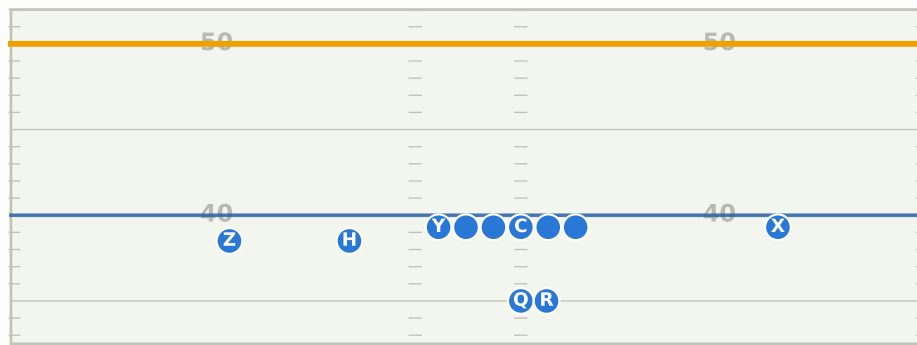


Figure 12: First-and-10 at the offense's own 40. The ball is on the right hash. The offense lines up three receivers to its left and leaves one (X) alone on the right.

Which side of this formation is the field side? Why would the offense put its three receivers there, and what does it give up?

Answer 1 is at the end of the chapter. Try it first.

💡 Predict the play 2: out of bounds, or not?

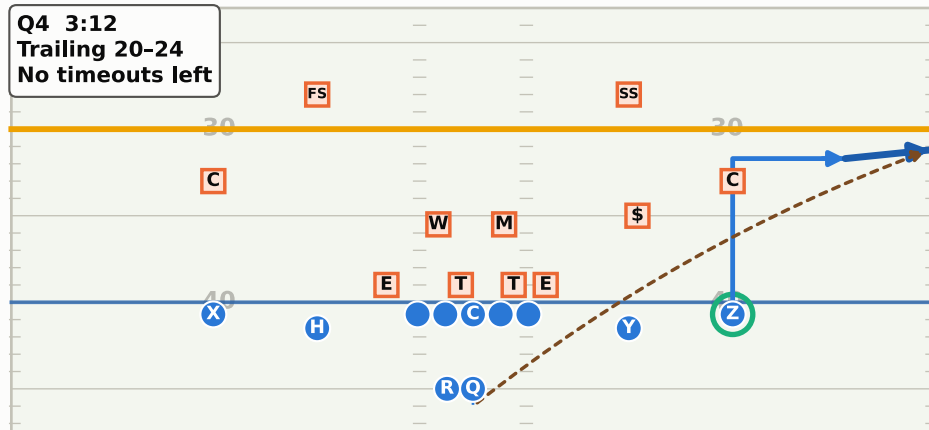


Figure 13: Fourth quarter, 3:12 left, the offense trailing 20–24 with no timeouts. Z (outlined) catches a quick out at the sideline 9 yards downfield and steps out of bounds, a yard short of the line to gain.

The clock stopped when Z stepped out. When will it start again? Would your answer change if this had happened with 6:12 left instead of 3:12?

Answer 2 is at the end of the chapter. Try it first.

💡 Predict the play 3: three points or seven?

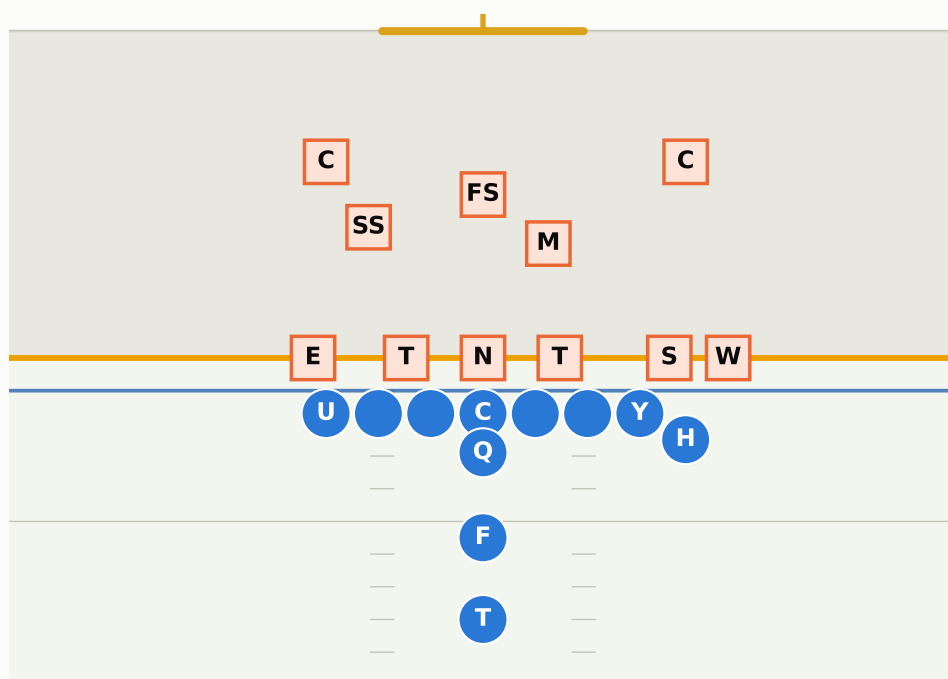


Figure 14: Fourth-and-goal at the 1, second quarter, score tied 7–7. The offense has sent out its heavy goal-line group: three tight ends, a fullback and a tailback. The defense has packed the line. The yellow line to gain is the goal line itself. The kicker is warming up on the sideline.

Kick the field goal or go for the touchdown? Put a number on each choice.

Answer 3 is at the end of the chapter. Try it first.

Takeaways

- The field is a 120-yard grid: a 100-yard field of play and two 10-yard end zones. **The goal line is in** the end zone, and only the ball has to break its plane; **the sidelines and end lines are out**, and any part of the player touching them is enough.
- **Every play starts on or between the hash marks.** With the ball on a hash, the field splits into a wide (field) side and a short (boundary) side, and offenses and defenses plan by them. The NFL's hashes are narrow, so its field is nearly symmetrical; college's wider hashes make the wide side huge.
- Points come in a handful of sizes: **6** for a touchdown, then **1** (kick from the 15) or **2** (play from the 2) on the try, **3** for a field goal, and **2 plus the ball** for a safety. The **four-point gap between 7 and 3** drives red-zone play, fourth-down decisions and late-game math.
- Possessions are scarce, about eleven per team per game, and a team only gets the ball back by stopping the other one or after it scores.
- The **game clock** keeps running after a tackle in bounds and stops for incompletions, out-of-bounds plays, scores, changes of possession, timeouts and flags; out of bounds stops it until the snap only late in each half. The **play clock** gives the offense 40 seconds (or 25) to snap. Trailing teams fight to stop the game clock; leading teams make the two clocks run together.
- A game is four 15-minute quarters with a two-minute warning near the end of each half, a halftime that resets possession and timeouts, and an overtime in which, since 2025, both teams get the ball in every game.

Connections

Builds on: nothing. This is the first chapter.

Sets up: Downs, Distance, and Field Position puts the grid to work: four downs, the line to gain, and field position as a currency, with a first look at expected points, the number that prices the 7-versus-3 choice exactly. The Twenty-Two puts players on the field, including the kicker, holder and long snapper behind every field goal. What a Play Really Is fills the 40 seconds of the play clock. Further on: Kicking and Punting and Kickoffs and Returns (the kicking game and its fast-changing rules), Red Zone, Goal Line, and Short Yardage, Clock and Game Management (overtime, the out-of-bounds rule, the 10-second runoff and every late-game clock decision), and Win Probability and Decision Analysis.

Case studies: the 2024 Eagles' goal-line game and the tush push appear again in Red Zone, Goal Line, and Short Yardage; Andy Reid's Chiefs, on both ends of this chapter's film rooms, are the subject of Andy Reid's Chiefs.

Go deeper

- The **NFL rulebook** is shorter and more readable than its reputation. Rule 1 (the field), Rule 4 (game timing) and Rule 11 (scoring) cover everything in this chapter, at [operations.nfl.com](https://www.nfl.com/operations).
- NFL Football Operations' "**Learn the game**" pages and its glossary of football terms are a good plain-English companion.
- Pat Kirwan, *Take Your Eye Off the Ball* (2010; 2nd ed. 2015): written by a former NFL coach and scout for fans; good on how the field's landmarks shape what players do.
- The Pro Football Hall of Fame's year-by-year **history pages** trace how hash marks, goal posts and scoring rules got where they are.

Answers to Predict the play

Answer 1.

The left side is the field (wide) side. The ball is on the right hash, so there's about 30 yards between the ball and the left sideline and about 24 to the right sideline. The offense put its three receivers into the bigger space so they have room to spread out and run routes that break away from each other, and so a run or screen to that side has room to get outside. The single receiver goes into the boundary, where he works one-on-one against his defender, with the sideline close by.

What it gives up: three receivers to the field tells the defense where most of the offense's options are. Defenses that play "field" and "boundary" roles can slide their safeties toward the wide side and leave the boundary corner alone against X. That is exactly the one-on-one some offenses *want*, if X is their best receiver. You'll see both versions every Sunday: "formation to the field" is the common default, and lining up into the boundary is a deliberate surprise. (Spread and Modern Formations names this formation; for now, just find the wide side.)

Answer 2.

At 3:12 it stays stopped until the next snap. Inside the last five minutes of the game, a play that ends out of bounds stops the clock until the ball is snapped again. The offense, with no timeouts, gets a “free” stoppage just by getting its receiver out, which is exactly why it threw to the sideline. It can now take its time choosing a play for second-and-1 without burning clock.

At 6:12 the answer changes. Earlier in the half, the clock stops only until the officials have re-spotted the ball on the hash and the referee signals ready for play. Then it starts again, and the play clock is running too, so the offense loses most of the advantage.

Now think like the defense, which is protecting a 4-point lead. It wants the clock running, so it would much rather tackle Z in bounds, even after a few more yards, than let him get out. You’ll see defensive backs play inside their receivers in this situation, taking away the throws over the middle (where a tackle keeps the clock running anyway) and daring the offense to complete passes outside before it runs out of time. The detail of the out-of-bounds rule is in Clock and Game Management.

Answer 3.

Go for it, and most NFL coaches now would. Do it in points:

- **The field goal** is a 19-yarder (the 1 plus 18). From there kickers almost never miss: in the 2016–2025 regular seasons, 99% of field goals tried on fourth-and-goal from the 1 or 2 were good. Call it **3 points**.
- **Going for it** from the 1 or 2 scored a touchdown 55% of the time in the same seasons. A touchdown plus an extra point (about 96% good) is worth almost 7, so on average going for it is worth about $0.55 \times 6.96 \approx 3.8$ points.²⁹

Going for it wins on raw points, and that’s before counting the miss. If the offense fails, the opponent takes over at its own 1-yard line, the worst field position in football. NFL teams starting a drive there have been, on average, slightly more likely to give up the next score than to get it. If the kick succeeds, the opponent gets a kickoff and usually starts around its own 30–35, a much better spot. So even the failure case isn’t a disaster, and the success case is worth four extra points.

That’s why teams have changed their behavior: on fourth-and-goal from the 1 or 2, NFL teams went for it 57% of the time in 2016 and 85% of the time in 2025. The crowd at the top of the chapter wasn’t being irrational when it booed the kicker. It was doing the 7-versus-3 math. How teams turn this into a fourth-down model, and when the answer flips (late in a game, the score matters more than the average), is in Win Probability and Decision Analysis.

²⁹Course calculation from nflverse play-by-play, 2016–2025 regular seasons: fourth-and-goal snaps from the 1 or 2 (593 plays): runs and passes scored a touchdown on 55% (236 of 426); field goals were good on 99% (166 of 167); teams went for it on 57% of these snaps in 2016 and 85% in 2025. Expected points for a first-and-10 at a team’s own 1-yard line averaged about -0.5 in 2023–2025 (nflverse ep), against about $+1.6$ at its own 35.